

When two operators are of the same level, Excel will calculate from left to right. For example, “=2*3/4” will cause the multiplication to be done first, and then the division.

If you use parentheses, what is inside them will be calculated first, irrespective of the precedence order. For example, “= 2*(3/4)” will calculate 3 divided by 4 before multiplying by 2.

When you are using complex formulas where you may have multiple parentheses nested one within another, you will need to ensure that for each open bracket there is a closing bracket. If you make a mistake, Excel will bring up an error and automatically suggest corrections. For example, the formula “=SUM(SUM(A4:C4), SUM(A5:C5))” has the final outer bracket missing. Excel will detect this and suggest corrections, at which point you should review your formula and make corrections if needed.

What makes Excel so powerful is its inbuilt functions. To use them, click on the Formula tab. You get a wide range of functions and formulas that you can choose from the Function Library group.

The functions are in ten categories:

- Financial
- Logical
- Text
- Date & Time
- Lookup & Reference
- Math & Trigonometry

And, by clicking on the More Functions button:

- Statistical
- Engineering
- Cube
- Information

The functions’ names are quite self-explanatory, but we’ll be delving into some of the function categories in more detail in later sections. The function categories Text, Lookup & Reference,